

Introduction

A lot has been said, written and discussed about cloud computing over the past decade. From being a buzzword in its early stages, to a fashionable catchphrase in IT circles, to a downright cliché and to sometimes actually even being used correctly, the term has seen its share of ups and downs. The problem however is that as with any phrase that develops organically (like say Web 2.0) there are always bound to be different definitions propagated by different stakeholders. Some believe it is the ability to lease out scalable virtual servers on demand. Some believe complex applications being delivered to end users through a web browser is also cloud computing. Some believe that vendors who provide the infrastructure and underlying frameworks that enable developers to create their own remote apps, are engaging in a form of cloud computing.

Cloud computing may be a lot of things but it certainly isn't what Mr. Vishwa Bandhu Gupta, a former additional commissioner of income-tax, believes it is. If you haven't yet seen the video we're referencing, do yourself a favour and do watch it – <http://dgit.in/raincomput>. Mr. Gupta warns unsuspecting viewers of catastrophic data loss if clouds burst into rain. It's hilarious but we won't spoil it for you any further, so do watch.

Coming back to the topic at hand. In this book we'll delve into the basics first; debunking myths and answering fundamental questions like "is cloud computing just another fancy term for the internet?". While painting a picture at a broader level, the book will be focusing primarily on the SaaS (Software as a service) part of things, which even includes web services that help you perform a particular task by offloading compute power to the server side – say transcoding a video remotely. These are, after all, the areas of cloud computing that touch everyday consumers such as yourself.

The book takes a look at everything from the various options available in cloud storage and syncing to collaboration services. There's a bit of serious stuff such as cloud based productivity services but even some fun stuff like photo editing in the cloud. You won't believe the number of services that exist out there and all you need to tap into them is a simple browser.

So do try them out, and write in to us at editor@tbinkdigit.com with your valuable suggestions. Happy reading. 